

Sujoy Ghosh, the four shorts in *Lust Stories 2* follow the formula laid down by its predecessor. At least on paper, these four narratives aim to question the morality of lust and whether it is entirely possible to uphold societal norms while giving in to one's primal desires.

In that sense, the intention of *Lust Stories 2* is well-meaning, but the execution falls prey to familiar failures. Take, for instance, the presence of just one female voice in the roster of four filmmakers, the same count as last time around. If the idea was to offer Indian audiences an updated understanding of lust, shouldn't it have been a priority to challenge the gaze with which these narratives are constructed in the first place?

That is to say, the main undoing of *Lust Stories 2* is its prevalent male gaze. Sharma, Ghosh and Balki's shorts skirt around the complexities of desires instead of approaching them head-first, their limitations visible in the hesitation of the filmmakers to challenge convention. Each of these narratives then feels more like a dated gimmick than an indictment of a repressed society. Even though these shorts are led by female protagonists, their inner turmoil comes across as manufactured rather than lived-in. Take, for example, Balki's segment, which centres sexual fulfilment as the chief ingredient in any long-lasting marriage but prefers to keep actual conversations about premarital sex and orgasms off-screen.

Only Sen Sharma, who returns to directing after six years, manages to tread the fine line between sex and subversion, diminishing the distance between women's minds and their bodies. Shome and Subhash play off each other with such charged chemistry that it both rankles and delights, effortlessly shattering barriers of civility and complicity. For Sen Sharma, the priority was locating the dissonance between what turns women on and the varied things that stop them from admitting it to not just the world but also to themselves. Suffused with sexual tension and yearning, the film shows more than it tells, ending up as a compelling tale of female liberation and loneliness. That it is the only short that feels deserving of its place in *Lust Stories 2* is telling of Netflix's failures in mounting yet another anthology that will be forgotten more easily than it will be remembered. ■

Poulomi Das

Srivastava, marks his debut as a lead in an OTT series. It is a much more ambitious outing. In the thriller series streaming on JioCinema, Paul plays Pawan Kumar Bawaria a.k.a. Prince, a con artist who assumes different identities to operate big-ticket scams across India. "Audiences connect me with hosting where they feel I have raised the bar, but it feels great to play the lead in *Rafuchakkar*, where I have essayed five different roles in my OTT debut," says Paul.

"When I got the call for the show, I was really surprised because I'm generally considered for comic roles. I'm the fun guy, the happy guy. As a creative artist, though, I was delighted," he adds. Since he had to play five roles, Paul had long discussions with the director over the script to figure out the looks and mannerisms of the characters. Srivastava was supportive. "I completely surrendered to him and he has played a vital role in my performance," says Paul.

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The series was shot in locations across India like Udaipur, Amritsar, Ahmedabad and Delhi. The shoot itself lasted around 75 days, spread over a period of five months. The result is a dark, racy thriller, with a great many twists and turns. Priya Bapat as the public prosecutor Ritu Arora serves as the perfect counterpoint to Paul's Prince. "I had to ensure I was in character. The difficult part was that on the same day, I would be playing more than one character," he says.

So, has Paul finally made the subtle shift from TV host to bonafide thespian? According to him, the feedback has been encouraging. "People are telling me they would love to see me in more thrillers. No one has said 'Come on, stick to your hosting and comedy and don't try all these things'." Paul did throw himself into the role, even gaining and losing weight rapidly to fit into the skin of the characters. *Rafuchakkar* is a fast-paced series that maintains its relentless tempo throughout. However, only time will tell whether it was the best vehicle for his metamorphosis. ■

Amit Dixit